Funding Options for the East Carroll Parish Clerk of Court

Prepared for **Rene Thomas Williams, Clerk of Court**, East Carroll Parish. November 9, 2026.

Prepared by: _____

This briefing lists every source of money and free help we found for the Clerk of Court's office: grants, state programs, Police Jury obligations, free services, and new earned revenue. It also answers one question directly: **is any money being withheld from the Police Jury or the Clerk's office?**

How to read the status column.

- **Open:** apply any time.
- **Cycle:** recurs on a known schedule.
- **Ask:** depends on a phone call or a written request.
- **Paused:** no funding right now. Keep a project ready.

[verify] marks a fact that could not be confirmed from a primary source. Federal programs changed a great deal in 2025 and 2026, so confirm each line with the agency before relying on it. The companion document `CLERK_AND_PARISH_FUNDING.md` has the longer research.

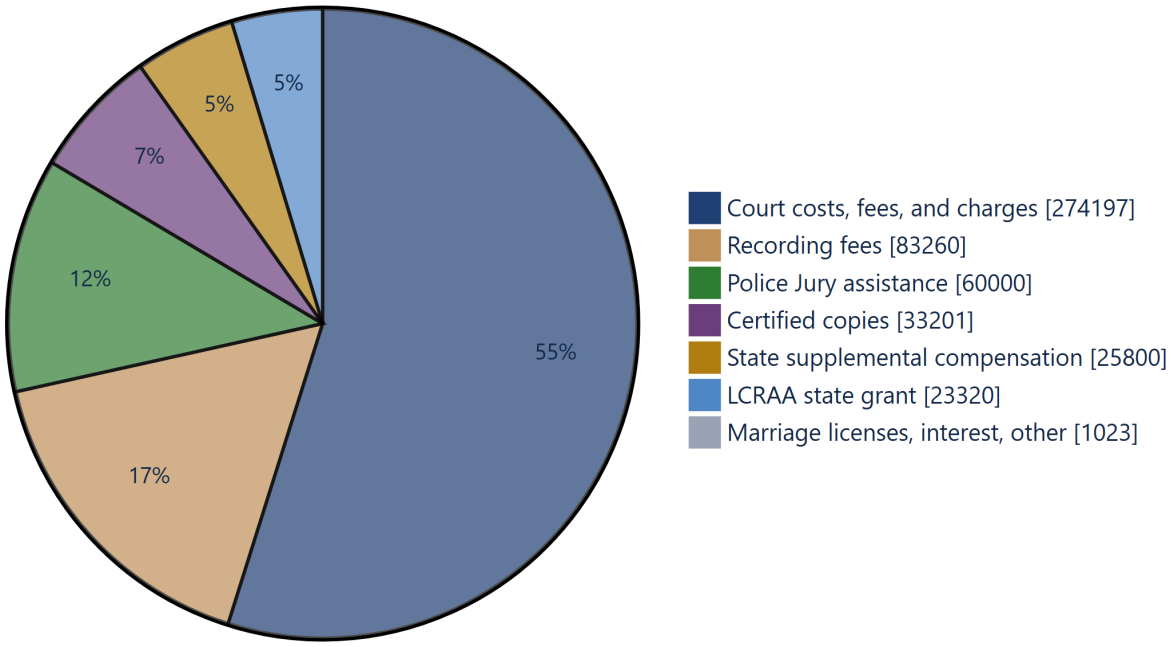
1. At a glance

- **No money is being withheld from the Police Jury or the Clerk's office.** Neither is on the Legislative Auditor's non-compliance list. The list was generated Nov. 5, 2026. Three other East Carroll bodies are on it (Section 3).
- **The office runs on fees, and fees fell.** Court costs dropped from $330,421 in FY2022 to $274,197 in FY2023, a 17% decline. The Police Jury covered the gap with $60,000 at the Clerk's request.
- **Best near-term money:** the state clerks' remote-access grant (**LCRAA**), next due **Jan. 31, 2027**. It paid the office $23,320 in FY2023.
- **The Police Jury owes the office equipment by law.** On the Clerk's written request, the Jury must supply office furniture, equipment, and record books (R.S. 13:784). The request should reach the Jury while its 2027 budget is being set.
- **Free help is available now:** cybersecurity assessments from the state and CISA, plus a free .gov web address.
- **One deadline protects all of the above:** the office's FY2026 audit is due to the Legislative Auditor by **Dec. 31, 2026**.

2. Where the office's money comes from today

Latest audit found online: fiscal year ended June 30, 2023 (unmodified opinion, no findings).

Clerk of Court revenue, FY ended June 30, 2023, total $500,801

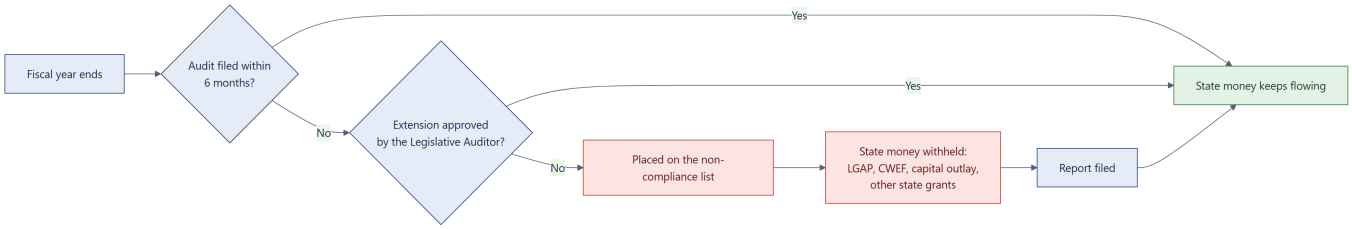


Item	FY2022	FY2023	What it means
Court costs, fees, and charges	$330,421	$274,197	Down 17%. The East Carroll Banner reported the loss came partly from companies such as John Deere moving clerical work away from the office
Recording fees	$80,350	$83,260	Steady
Certified copies	$18,319	$33,201	Up 81%
Police Jury ("local funds" in the audit)	none	$60,000	Requested by the Clerk and approved by the Jury
State grants	$7,530	$23,320	The FY2023 amount was the LCRAA grant, so the office has already won this grant
General Fund balance at year end	$87,834	$128,472	About $40,000 of slack a year. Not enough to fund a new position from fees
Staff		4 employees	

Sources: Clerk FY2023 audit; East Carroll Banner, Dec. 28, 2023.

3. Is money being withheld? The Police Jury check

What withholding means in Louisiana. Every local government must file its audit within six months of its fiscal year end (R.S. 24:513). An entity that misses the deadline without an approved extension goes on the Legislative Auditor's **non-compliance list**. Under R.S. 39:72.1, **state money cannot be paid to an entity on that list.** It comes off the list when the report arrives or an extension is approved.



Status as of the Nov. 5, 2026 list

East Carroll entity	On the list?	Detail
Police Jury	**No**	The FY2025 audit was due June 30, 2026. The Jury filed for an extension (Banner, Sept. 15, 2026). Because it is not on the list, the report has either been received or the extension was approved. **Ask the Secretary-Treasurer which, and the new due date.** If that date passes without a report, state money stops, including the courthouse capital outlay
Clerk of Court	**No**	The FY2024 and FY2025 reports were not found online, but the office is not listed, so the Auditor has them or approved extensions **[verify]**. **FY2026 report due Dec. 31, 2026**
Sheriff	No	FY2025 report is on file
Communications District (E911)	**Yes, 3 years**	Reviews missing for FY2023, FY2024, and FY2025. State money is blocked, which matters for any next-generation 911 or shared-staff plan
Recreation District	**Yes**	FY2024 sworn financial statements missing (due Mar. 31, 2025)
Soil and Water Conservation District	**Yes**	FY2026 sworn financial statements missing (due Sept. 30, 2026)

Source: Legislative Auditor non-compliance list (CSV export); consequences of a late report.

Is the Police Jury holding back money owed to the Clerk?

No sign of it in the public record.

- **Courthouse costs:** the Clerk's audit states the Police Jury pays the cost of maintaining and operating the courthouse, as R.S. 33:4715 requires.
- **2023 assistance:** the Jury approved the Clerk's $60,000 request.
- **Criminal court costs:** the Jury paid $1,460 in FY2023; the Sheriff paid $38,454.

Three things are worth watching:

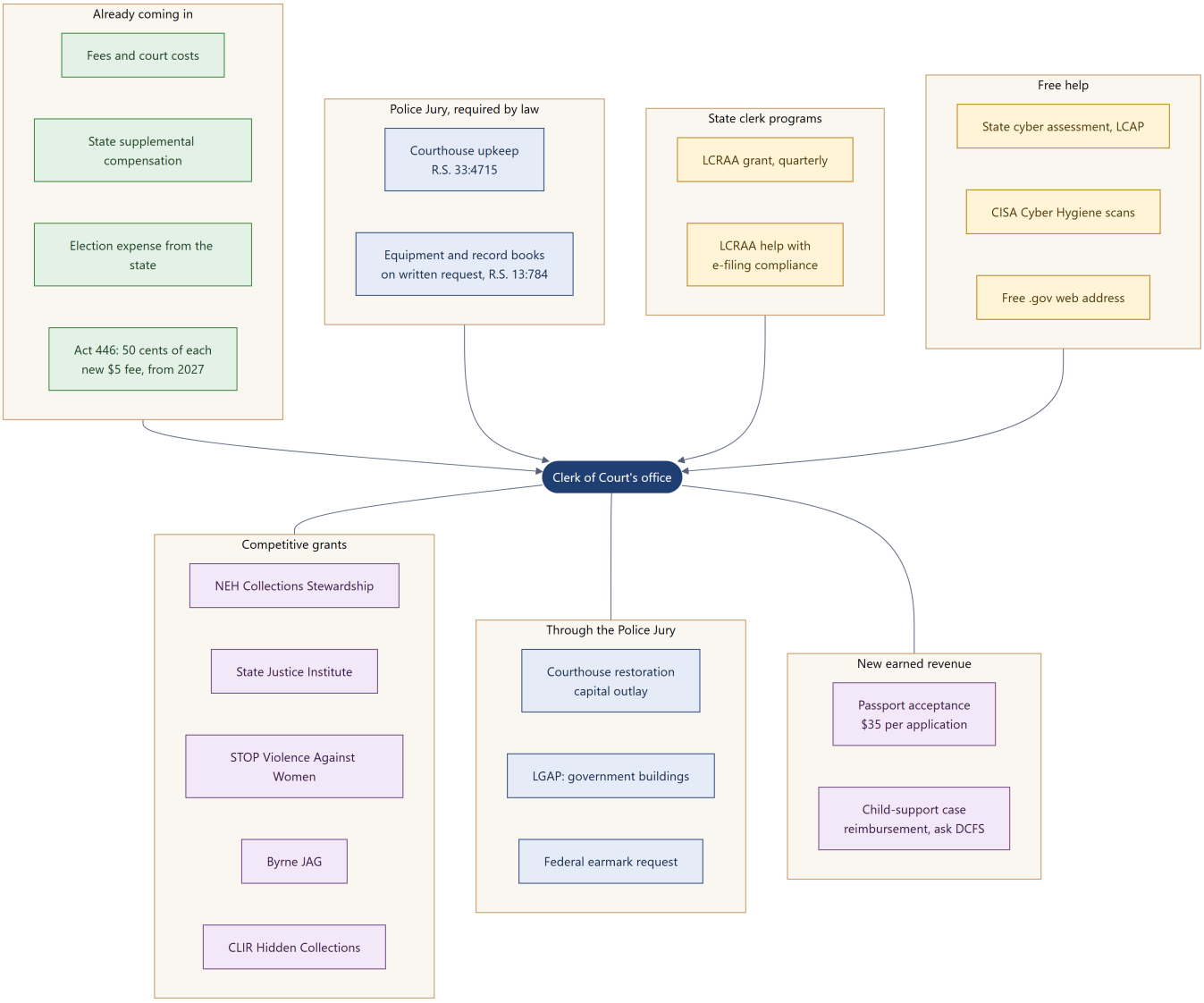
1. **Courthouse maintenance tax.** The Jury's FY2024 audit lists the 2.53-mill courthouse maintenance tax with an expiration of 2024. If it was not renewed, courthouse upkeep now competes with everything else in the General Fund. **[verify the renewal]**
2. **Tight Jury finances.** The FY2024 audit shows the General Fund and Road Fund over budget, and a $7,787 deficit in the Criminal Court Fund. On April 21, 2026 the Banner reported jurors had gone four months without financial statements at committee meetings. Full statements were back by July 2026.
3. **FY2024 audit findings (Jury, not Clerk).** Federal programs were clean. Three state-law findings were reported:
   - vehicle-use reporting
   - minutes from June to September 2024 missing or unpublished
   - required ethics and harassment training not taken

The "adverse" opinion in that report covers only the Jury's choice to leave the Sheriff, Assessor, Clerk, and other separately elected offices out of its statements. It does not concern the Clerk's money.

Sources: Police Jury FY2024 audit; Banner, Sept. 15, 2026; Banner, Apr. 21, 2026; Banner, July 21, 2026.

4. The full funding map

Top: money and help the office already has or is owed. Bottom: money the office can go after.



5. Every option, by type

5a. Money the office already receives or is owed

Source	What it is	Size	Status
Fees, court costs, recording (R.S. 13:781)	Go into the Clerk's Salary Fund, which pays staff and office costs	About $391,000 in FY2023	Ongoing
State supplemental compensation	Paid by the state	$25,800	Ongoing
Election expense	The state pays the Clerk for election duties	$1,800 in FY2023	Ongoing
Act 446 of 2026 (HB 916)	A new $5 fee for statewide e-filing. **The Clerk keeps 50 cents of each fee**, LCRAA keeps 50 cents, and the rest goes to a state court technology fund	Small but recurring	Starts Jan. 1, 2027 **[verify]**; ends Aug. 1, 2029 unless extended
Police Jury: courthouse (R.S. 33:4715)	The Jury maintains and operates the courthouse and the office space	Jury budget	Ongoing
Police Jury: equipment and record books (R.S. 13:784, 33:4713)	On the Clerk's request, the Jury must provide "all necessary office furniture, equipment, and record books"	Jury budget	**Ask: send a written list before the 2027 Jury budget is adopted**

Source for the Jury duties: Legislative Auditor, Parish Obligations to Fund Other Public Officials.

5b. State clerk programs

Program	Pays for	Size / match	Next date	Status
LCRAA grant (Louisiana Clerks' Remote Access Authority)	Hardware, software, and services to scan and index records onto the statewide portal; e-transactions; emergency operations	Office got $23,320 in FY2023. No match stated. Needs 2 vendor proposals and a financial needs assessment	**Jan. 31, 2027**, then Apr. 30, Jul. 31, Oct. 31	**Cycle**
LCRAA compliance help (Act 694 of 2024)	Every clerk had to offer e-filing, e-recording, and remote access by Jan. 1, 2026. LCRAA supports members in getting there	In-kind	Now	**Ask** whether any piece is unfinished

5c. Free help, no application fee or match

Program	What you get	How to start
Louisiana Cybersecurity Assurance Program (GOHSEP, National Guard, Office of Technology Services)	Free vulnerability assessment, monitoring, incident response	Email LCAP@la.gov
CISA Cyber Hygiene	Free weekly external scans of the office's internet-facing systems	Email vulnerability@cisa.dhs.gov
.gov domain	A trusted official web address for the office's site at no cost	Request through get.gov
Website rebuild	A draft replacement site is ready for the office's review	Volunteer; see `clerk-site/`

Not a source, so skip these:

- HAVA election-security money goes to the Secretary of State, not to clerks.
- State Archives imaging is a paid service, not a grant.
- MS-ISAC is now a paid membership.

5d. Competitive grants

Program	Pays for	Size / match	Next date	Status
NEH Collections Stewardship	Preserving and digitizing historic records, such as early Delta land and court books	$50K to $500K. No match	**Dec. 15, 2026**	**Open.** Large and competitive; best with a university partner
State Justice Institute Technical Assistance	Expert help on e-filing, cybersecurity, court operations	Up to $75K. 50% match, at least 20% cash. No salaries	Feb. 1, May 1, Aug. 1, 2027	**Cycle.** Needs Louisiana Supreme Court approval
STOP Violence Against Women (through LCLE)	Systems to track and transmit protective orders	Varies. 25% match	Through the LCLE district director	**Cycle**
Byrne JAG (through LCLE)	Court technology, hardware, software	Small. No match	Through the LCLE district	**Cycle.** May go through the Jury or the 6th Judicial District Court **[verify]**
CLIR Digitizing Hidden Collections	Digitizing records of under-documented communities	$50K to $300K	About fall 2027	**Cycle.** Partner with a university
NHPRC Archival Projects	Online access to county and early legal records	Up to $150K	None posted	**Paused**
NEH Preservation Assistance	Preservation assessment, disaster plan, supplies	Up to $10K	None posted	**Paused**
State and Local Cybersecurity Grant Program	Cyber planning and fixes	Up to $200K. 40% match	None posted	**Paused**

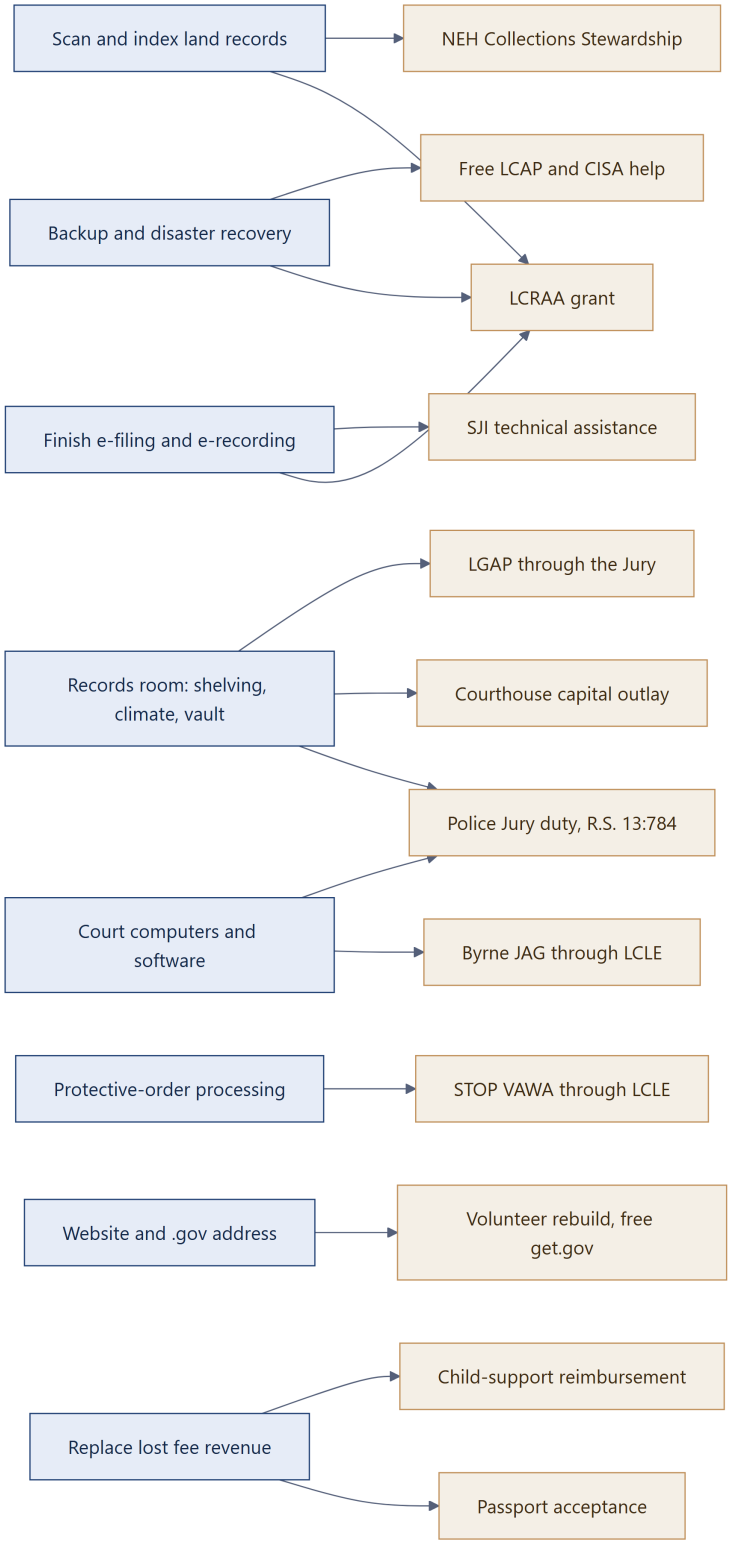
5e. Through the Police Jury (the Jury applies, the office benefits)

Program	How it helps the Clerk's office	Status
2026 capital outlay, East Carroll Courthouse assessment and restoration, about $10.1M	Engineers are weighing renovation against a new building (KNOE, Dec. 2025). **Make sure the records vault, climate control, shelving, and an accessible public counter are in the scope**	Authorized; not all cash-funded. Depends on the Jury staying off the non-compliance list
LGAP (Local Government Assistance Program)	"Government buildings" are eligible, so records-room improvements can be included. Parish allocation $60,000, cap $100,000, no match	**Cycle.** Last window Nov. 3, 2025 to Feb. 28, 2026. Next not yet posted **[verify]**. Needs a Jury resolution and letters from the state senator and representative
Federal earmark (Community Project Funding / Congressionally Directed Spending)	Records digitization or courthouse work as a named project	Requests usually go to Rep. Letlow and Sens. Cassidy and Kennedy, February to April
USDA Community Facilities	Courthouse buildings and equipment in rural areas	Nearly all FY2026 grant money was earmarked **[verify]**. Use the earmark route instead

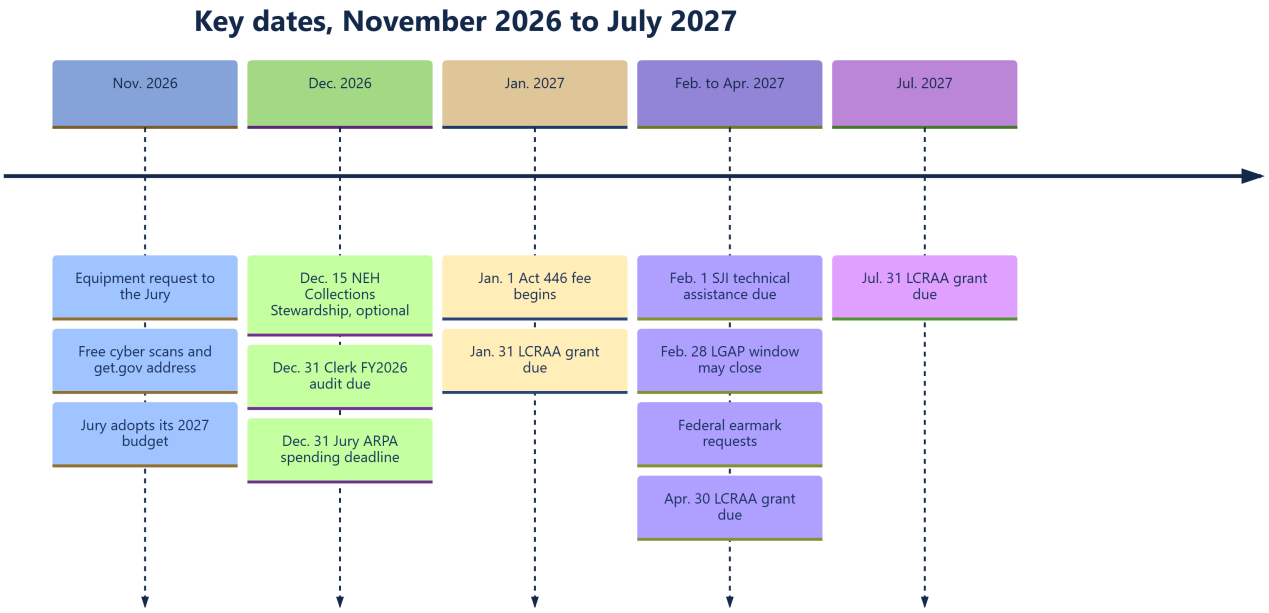
5f. New earned revenue

Idea	How it works	Status
Passport acceptance facility	Clerk's offices across Louisiana accept passport applications for the U.S. Department of State. **The facility keeps the $35 execution fee** on each new application. Requires State Department designation and agent training	**Ask** whether the office already offers it **[verify]**. The draft website does not list it
Child-support case reimbursement (Title IV-D)	Louisiana law lets a court enter a cooperative agreement with the Department of Children and Family Services on child-support collections and costs (R.S. 46:236.11). Federal Title IV-D money reimburses part of that work	**Ask** DCFS Child Support Enforcement whether the office's child-support work qualifies **[verify]**

6. Which source fits which project



7. Calendar



8. Suggested first steps

#	Step	Who	When
1	Confirm the FY2026 audit is on track for Dec. 31, 2026	Clerk, auditor	Now
2	Send the Police Jury a written list of needed equipment and record books under R.S. 13:784	Clerk	Before the 2027 Jury budget is adopted
3	Sign up for the free CISA scans and LCAP assessment; request a `.gov` address	Office, with volunteer help	November
4	Gather two vendor proposals for scanning and indexing; prepare the LCRAA application	Volunteer drafts, Clerk signs	Due Jan. 31, 2027
5	Ask the Jury to name the Clerk's records vault and public counter in the courthouse restoration scope	Clerk	Next Jury meeting
6	Call about passport acceptance and child-support reimbursement	Office	December
7	Decide on NEH Collections Stewardship. Go only with a university partner	Clerk	By Dec. 1

What I can do at no cost to the office:

- draft the LCRAA application and the equipment request
- collect vendor quotes
- handle the cybersecurity sign-ups
- finish the website
- keep this calendar

The Clerk makes every decision and signs everything.

9. Questions to confirm with the office

1. Is every part of the Act 694 e-filing, e-recording, and remote-access setup working?
2. Were the FY2024 and FY2025 audits filed, and who is doing the FY2026 audit?
3. Has the office received LCRAA grants since FY2023? How much, and for what?
4. Has the Police Jury ever been asked in writing for equipment under R.S. 13:784? Is anything owed to the office now?
5. Was the courthouse maintenance tax renewed?
6. Does the office accept passport applications?
7. Is there a child-support (IV-D) cooperative agreement in place?
8. Who holds the login for the website domain?

Sources

- Clerk of Court FY2023 audit: Legislative Auditor
- Police Jury FY2024 audit (LaPorte CPAs, June 20, 2025): Legislative Auditor
- Non-compliance list, generated Nov. 5, 2026: CSV export
- Late-report rules (R.S. 24:513, R.S. 39:72.1): Legislative Auditor guide
- Parish obligations to other officials (R.S. 13:784, 33:4713, 33:4715): Legislative Auditor
- East Carroll Banner: Dec. 28, 2023, Apr. 21, 2026, July 21, 2026, Sept. 15, 2026
- KNOE, courthouse accessibility, Dec. 10, 2025: article
- Act 446 of 2026 (HB 916): bill history
- Act 694 of 2024: text
- LCRAA grant application: form
- 2026 capital outlay, East Carroll: HB2 sheet
- Grant programs: links in each table row above